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SOLDIERS OF THE FLEET, IN ACTION

From **From the FMF (from-the-fmf)**

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On July 20, 2019, the British flagged merchant vessel *Stena Impero* was seized by the Iranian Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC).[1] (about:blank) Four small craft encircled the tanker, then a helicopter hovered overhead and several masked, armed men fast roped onto the deck of the *Stena Impero*.[2] (about:blank) The tanker and its crew were forcibly taken to Bandar Abbas port in Iran. This incident was part of a larger trend of increased hostility and confrontation that began with the May 2018 American withdrawal from the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), commonly referred to as the "Iran nuclear deal". Significant events prior to the *Stena Impero* seizure included attacks on merchant vessels in the Gulf of Oman in May and June 2019, shootdowns of drones, and seizure of an Iranian flagged vessel off of Gibraltar suspected of sanctions violations.[3][4][5][6] (about:blank) The *Stena Impero* seizure showcased a set of tactical capabilities of the IRGC that were not widely known previously. Maritime traffic in the narrow Strait of Hormuz (SOH) now had an added threat; seizure. Our adversary had exploited a gap that existed in this strategic chokepoint.

Third Platoon, Fleet Antiterrorism Security Team (FAST) Company A (AF3), had forward deployed to Naval Support Activity Bahrain in mid June. There are always FAST platoons prestaged and nested into Fleet hierarchy, in Rota, Spain with 6th Fleet, in Yokosuka, Japan with 7th Fleet, and in Manama, Bahrain with 5th Fleet. This integration into Fleet organization makes FAST platoons easily accessible by Fleet admirals when they have a need for a scalable, rapidly deployable force of special infantry Marines capable of independent operations.

FAST platoons, because of their relationship with Fleet commands, are an exemplar for Marine integration into Fleet operations at the tactical level. As the Marine Corps retools its force structure to face a peer level threat that favors asymmetric tactics, knowing how FAST has operated for its 33 years of existence can help inform service level policy makers as to how best shape our force to win tactical actions that support our defensive strategic posture. Furthermore, FAST's habitual relationships with other military services and government agencies makes for a great example on how to best integrate into the larger goals and operating machinery of American foreign policy.

The American reaction to the *Stena Impero* was one of shock and concern. To national security watchers, this aggression from the Iranians was not surprising, but it was more audacious than previous encounters. Commander, Fifth Fleet (C5F), ordered his subordinate commands, the various task forces, to give him options to deter further Iranian aggression in this strategic maritime choke point. An overview of these task forces can be found at https://www.cusnc.navy.mil/Task-Forces/. AF3, having completed a deployment to 6th Fleet in December 2019, was well familiar with Navy task organization, and this absolutely facilitated planning and integration.

FAST's unofficial motto is "Deter, detect, defend." Initially founded in response to Libyan and Iranian state sponsored terrorism in the 1980s, FAST has been invovled in security and combat operations continuously since its inception. The pre-deployment training program emphasizes supporting interagency entities, operations short of full scale war, and high levels of proficiency on a wide variety of weapons systems. While small in size, FAST brings a flexibility to the table that is an absolute force multiplier. FAST participated in the invasion of Panama, supported government agencies in Somalia, conducted security operations in Haiti in the 1990s, responded to the Khobar Towers bombing in 1996, responded to the East Africa embassy bombings in 1998, responded to the USS Cole bombing, supported Deptartment of State during OPERATION IRAQI FREEDOM, and defended the US Embassy Yemen in 2012, among many others. The high tempo and wide array of missions and organizations that FAST has supported have created an organization that has integration deeply imbued into its culture.

In Fifth Fleet, FAST falls under TF 51/5. An integrated task force of approximately 60% Marines and 40% Sailors, this crisis response organization is commanded by a Marine brigadier general. It was created out of 5th MEB headquarters staff, and has control of the MEU (when in theater), Special Purpose MAGTF-Crisis Response-Central Command, the USS Lewis B. Puller, a Navy Expeditionary Resuscitative Surgical System, and FAST.

The majority of the options to counter Iran that were under consideration at TF 51/5 consisted of large movements of troops, vessels, and materiel. Demonstrations involving the MEU or the SPMAGTF, repositioning forces on the Arabian peninsula, and other similar options. They were all "big blue arrow" operations, events that showed resolve and capability, but were overmatch for the threat. This mismatch favors the revisionist power, as the time, expense, and strategic opportunity cost of repositioning a warship or MAGTF is significantly larger than the operational cost imposed on the IRGC when it threatens merchant vessels in the heavily trafficked Strait of Hormuz.

Enter FAST. When conducting contingency planning in response to this crisis, AF3 identified an opportunity to project American power in the maritime domain in a defensive, deterrent manner, consistent with previous methods of employment of FAST Marines. Using specialized insertion and extraction techniques to provide expeditionary security aboard American ships in an operation short of full scale conflict was right in the wheelhouse for FAST.

The date of inception of the plan by AF3 was 22 July 2019. The operation, in support of OPERATION SENTINEL, was executed 15-17 October 2019.[7] (about:blank) This nearly three month delay did not benefit American foreign policy, and did not improve stability in the strategic maritime chokepoint under threat. The international rules based order did not have control of the narrative during this time. During this period, Iran seized another two merchant vessels.[8][9] (about:blank) On 14 September Iran launched a missile attack on the ARAMCO facility in eastern Saudi Arabia, including a target that was less than 100 miles from C5F headquarters in Bahrain.[10] (about:blank) Additionally, the vessel that had been seized to precipitate raised security precautions, the *Stena Impero*, was released in late September.[11] (about:blank)

The difficulties causing delay were organizational, not tactical. The operation involved American defense attache´ offices in Qatar and United Arab Emirates, Coastal Riverine Squadron Mark VI patrol craft, Emirati customs and coast guard officers, Navy MH-60 helicopters, three US Navy destroyers, Navy C40s, Navy patrol craft in UAE, Naval Cooperation and Guidance for Shipping (NCAGS) Central Command, and all of their parent commands. The requisite coordination across task forces, in competition for scarce resources and time, added friction to building the concept of operations. Some of the adjacent naval task forces were less than enthusiastic about facilitating the endeavor. While some entities were very supportive, it was time consuming to get the whole "team" on board to support the operation. Ultimately it took the Maritime Operation Center Director's involvement to ensure priorities were synchronized.

Another delaying factor was the desire to have FAST Marines prove capabilities, with the intent of mitigating risk. The Marines spent time in the Embarked Security and Intelligence Team (ESIT) simulator, practiced being hoisted by a MH-60S, practiced insertion by patrol craft and boarding ships via pilot's ladder, conducted small boat operations and logistical rehearsals on an underway destroyer, and rehearsals aboard several merchant vessels. While these activities were not a waste of time, they were not anything that the FAST Marines were particularly unaccustomed to, and considering them "required preparatory training" further delayed execution of the admiral's intent. As the Marine Corps integrates further into Navy operations, it is imperative that the gaining commands fully understand the resident capabilities of the units that fall under their operational control.

FAST used this delay of execution to conduct other operations in CENTCOM. While continuously refining plans to protect American interests from aggressors in the Strait of Hormuz, FAST also conducted multilateral training in Jordan. While teaching the finer points of Close Quarters Battle (CQB) to partner military units, FAST defeated two unidentified drones that entered local airspace above the training area. This defensive operation in the electronic domain built trust with partner nation militaries who were present for the exercise, as it showed the ability to run a multi-domain defense at a low tactical level. FAST also conducted numerous security operations to assist the Naval Expeditionary Combat Commands (NECC) of Task Force 56 in their intelligence collections efforts. These NECC elements will be natural organizational allies of Marines as naval integration is pursued service wide, provided our services can understand how best to build such a relationship.

Once a US flagged merchant vessel (USFMV) was identified for protection and the requisite support structure emplaced by C5F, AF3 deployed from Naval Support Activity Bahrain to the Gulf of Oman. After nearly three months of preparation, the actions to get the FAST security detachment aboard the USFMV were conducted rapidly, and included fixed wing aircraft, non-military airfields, diplomatic pressure, patrol craft, and boarding ladders. Once aboard the USFMV in the Gulf of Oman, the FAST Marines immediately conducted a site reconnaissance to confirm assumptions previously made. Defensive positions were emplaced, including drone defense, and crew served weapon positions prioritized. Extra ammunition was staged at key locations, as were extra pyrotechnics. Drills to rehearse reactions to contact with the IRGC, particularly helicopters, were conducted. Table top exercises were done with the crew and civilian security team to ensure that all parties were operating off the same plan if the vessel became threatened. The radio operator established communications with a US Navy destroyer in vicinity of the USFMV, and then he functioned as the documentarian, with his mission being to capture photographic evidence of all interactions. The defensive mission alone was not the only goal, as we had no control of when and where the adversary chose to be aggressive. Our mission was to defend the vessel, *and prove to the world that the Iranians were the aggressor*.

The USFMV entered the Traffic Separation Scheme (TSS), steaming west into the SOH. The Marines went to stand-to, and remained there for the entirety of the SOH transit. Although October, it was still over 100 degrees and 100 percent humidity in the Arabian Gulf. The FAST Marines' aggressive physical conditioning program prior to deployment paid off, as they were able to maintain their defensive posts without suffering the effects of heat exhaustion, a legitimate concern under the conditions.

The Iranians did not attempt to board the vessel defended by FAST Marines, limiting their interactions to a 1000 yard pass off the starboard beam at 0100. The FAST Marines immediately went to stand-to, and remained there until the Iranian vessel was well out of range. The IRGC stood their distance. Prior to departing the USFMV, the FAST Marines used the ship's computer to send photographs documenting the defensive mission to TF 51/5, in order to increase the tempo of the COMMSTRAT mission. Once the USFMV entered the central Arabian Gulf, the FAST Marines were extracted via MH-60 hoist, and flown to NSA Bahrain.

Unfortunately, the photographs of a well guarded American merchant vessel did not get published until seven days after the mission was complete. This delay in execution was due to the level at which media needed to be approved for release. Again, the challenge was administrative, with the structure or the organization preventing a rapid tempo that would maximize actions to deter further Iranian aggression.

Lessons learned/Key Recommendations:

Identify skills that are common between Marine Corps Training and Readiness standards and the Navy's Personnel Qualification Standards. Identifying these, and coming to common language, opens up opportunities for interoperability without conducting time consuming "familiarization training". Our integration must begin before forward deployment, it must be a midset, not a phase on a training plan. Building common language and interoperable systems for tracking qualifications increases tempo once units are downrange and working together against our adversaries. Not only must our doctrines correlate, but our routine policies and TTPs need to be interwoven if we are to achieve meaningful integration between services.

Build the study of U.S. Navy task organizations and concepts of employment into Marine Corps Professional Military Education (PME). Currently, PME is singularly focused on USMC operations, and has very limited coverage of naval campaigns other than amphibious operations. USMC PME must dive into the various compositions and purposes of task forces/task groups/task units/task elements. This facilitates the establishment of temporary integrated organizations that can accomplish a mission and then return to their parent units. This flexible organization, if the appropriate level commander is given autonomy, creates a rapidity of response that will facilitate out cycling our adversaries in the fight for the narrative. In the above operation, a Task Group established under Task Force Sentinel would have prevented a great deal of difficulty in the preparations and coordination for the mission, and would have decreased response times, improving our ability to get inside our adversary's OODA loop.

Overmatch of assets in response to adversary aggression can show strength, but our adversaries are rapidly learning that they can easily portray it as bullying when they craft their version of the narrative. Furthermore, the decisions to execute these counter actions reside at high levels of command, and the Communications Strategy (COMMSTRAT) release authority is similarly removed from the action. This is where our adversaries have out cycled us: they use inexpensive, rapidly deployable units who are not valuable strategic or operational assets. They give them release authority of media of interactions with coalition vessels, which gives them such rapid tempo that American foreign policy is frequently playing catch up. Delegating release authority of media to the appropriate level will allow us to dominate the information space.

Establish standards for surge capacity berthing aboard the many U.S. Navy surface combatants. Being able to place a detachment of Marines on any grey hull increases flexibility, and puts forth the possibility that anywhere there is a U.S. navy ship there might be Marines. This broadens the spectrum of capabilities that these commanders have when executing the naval surface strategy, Distributed Lethality. FAST, with enthusiastic support from DDG sailors, determined that ammunition storage, weapons storage, and berthing for a Marine detachment up to a squad are easily solvable problems. Creating a OPNAVINST or similar DON policy towards tactical integration of Marines onto CRUDES will generate more employment options for commanders, and without increasing acquisition budgets.

Last but not least, the dedication and flexibility of the young Marines of AF3 was noteworthy. These young Marines, most only having graduated boot camp within the previous 18 months, were commended for their professionalism, discipline, and competence by the civilian mariners they protected. As the Marine Corps moves forward to properly array itself against new threats, it is important to remember that our young Marines need only an opportunity to serve, and a mission that is relevant to American foreign policy. Given these two small things, they will never fail to impress and do our Corps proud. Our fundamental ability to take a young person off the street and make them into a highly functioning member of a cohesive expeditionary team, even without years of pipeline training, is a fundamental strength that we cannot lose.

Conclusion:

In the face of aggression short of war in critical maritime chokepoints, the Navy-Marine Corps team needs to have the ability to take tactical action that creates strategic impact. A way to improve the enforcement of American foreign policy can be achieved by creating task organized integrated tactical units that are specifically geared to address the threats in a manner that maintains American control of the strategic narrative.While this article puts forth some far ranging recommendations, the fundamental manner in which FAST platoons deploy in support of Fleet forces can be used as a template to model further USMC integration into Fleet operations.

Alexander Corbett is an infantry officer who is currently assigned to Marine Corps Security Force Regiment. The contents of this article are solely the opinions of the author and do not reflect the opinions or policy of the United States Marine Corps or Department of Defense.

[1] (about:blank) https://www.bbc.com/news/uk-49053383.
[2] (about:blank) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oJszRfb7EfQ.
[3] (about:blank) https://www.washingtonpost.com/world/middle_east/two-saudi-oil-tankers-attacked-in-the-persian-gulf-amid-rising-iran-tensions/2019/05/13/c8907108-755e-11e9-bd25-c989555e7766_story.html.
[4] (about:blank) https://apnews.com/d67714ab8ac344a3b3af19cca1c20192.
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[9] (about:blank) https://www.middleeasteye.net/news/iran-detains-gulf-vessel-over-fuel-smuggling-uae-iranian-media.
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